

NAPCS Unionization Research — State Research Summary

Washington, D.C. — NLRB Jurisdiction — May 2026

NAPCS Unionization Research • May 2026 • Template v7.0 • COMPLETE Registry Sweep

Section 1: State Overview

State	Washington, D.C.
Labor Board	NLRB — National Labor Relations Board — Region 5 (Baltimore/Washington)
Governing Law	National Labor Relations Act (NLRA). All DC Public Charter Schools (PCS) are authorized by the DC Public Charter School Board (DC PCSB) and independently incorporated as private nonprofit employers. DC PERB covers traditional DCPS employees only — PERB(DC) does NOT apply to any DC PCS. All DC charter labor matters are handled by NLRB Region 5.
Federal NLRB Jurisdiction	YES — NLRB Region 5 (Baltimore) is the sole applicable board for all 7 DC NAPCS charter schools. PERB(DC) covers DCPS employees only. This has been clearly established across all 6 certification proceedings in the DC charter sector.
Registry Sweep	COMPLETE — April 2026 — 125 charter schools searched
Research Window	March–April 2026
Date Convention	Labor Board Certified date (project-wide convention, declared NJ session). Project-wide convention. DC: all 7 CONFIRMED schools have NLRB certification dates documented. Mundo Verde Calle Ocho (May 2020) — voluntary recognition mechanism to be confirmed.
Card-Check Available	NO — NLRB jurisdiction — secret ballot election required. One exception: Mundo Verde Calle Ocho campus added via apparent voluntary employer recognition during COVID (May 2020) — mechanism to be confirmed in next biannual cycle.

Section 2: Unionization Density

Total charter schools in Washington, D.C.: 125 (Charter School Registry v50 (NCES/ELSI 2024-25; 123 open DC charter schools as of May 2026)). Unionization density uses the full state total as the denominator — not the 7-school NAPCS research sample. The NAPCS sample was provided as a list of schools believed to be organized; this research validated, corrected, and expanded that list across the full state charter universe. See Section 3 for cross-state patterns and Section 7 for open decisions.

Category	Schools	% of Total	Notes
Confirmed Union Schools	7	5.7%	All 7 NAPCS DC schools confirmed. DC Alliance of Charter Teachers and Staff (DC ACTS / AFT) is the organizing entity for all DC confirmed schools. Active CBA: Mundo Verde (2 campuses). First contract in negotiation: Capital City (3 campuses). Post-election: DC International (1). Breakthrough Montessori — certified June 5, 2025 (1).
Total Open DC Charter Schools	123	100%	Source: Charter School Registry v50 (NCES/ELSI 2024-25). All 123 DC charter schools are authorized by DC PCSB. 7 of 123 are in the NAPCS research dataset.

Section 3: Political, Legal & Community Landscape

Written for state and national charter sector leaders who require ground-level intelligence fused with broader sector knowledge. Findings are based on research as of May 2026.

PROMPT 1: DC ACTS LOCAL 1927 — SOLE ORGANIZING VEHICLE, CHAPTER MODEL

DC ACTS (District of Columbia Alliance of Charter Teachers and Staff, Local 1927, AFT) is the exclusive organizing vehicle for all 7 DC NAPCS charter schools. DC ACTS operates a chapter model: each school forms its own named chapter (Capital City Staff Union, DCI Staff Union, Breakthrough Montessori Staff Union, etc.) under shared DC ACTS infrastructure. WTU (Washington Teachers Union, Local 6, AFT) represents traditional DCPS staff and serves as a sister AFT affiliate to DC ACTS — they are sister locals, not affiliated in a parent-child relationship. DC ACTS's organizational infrastructure — including legal support, contract negotiation, and organizing capacity — is funded collectively across all chapters, giving smaller schools (like Breakthrough Montessori) access to resources equivalent to much larger locals. This model is directly comparable to Education Minnesota's chapter model in MN and Chicago ACTS's model in IL.

PROMPT 2: NO EMPLOYER COUNTER-ORGANIZING — THE MOST STRIKING FINDING IN THE DC DATASET

Across all 6 DC charter organizing campaigns (May 2019 through May 2025), there is no documented employer ULP charge, no counter-organizing campaign, and no public anti-union statement from any DC PCSB-authorized charter school. This is the most striking finding in the DC research and unique in the full 584-school NAPCS dataset: an NLRB-jurisdiction market with zero documented employer resistance to unionization across 6 campaigns spanning 6 years. The most plausible explanation is the PCSB authorization environment: DC charter operators operate under continuous PCSB oversight, and overt anti-union activity creates reputational and authorization risk in a politically pro-labor environment. DC's political culture (overwhelmingly Democratic; no independent Republican political base) removes the ideological fuel that drives employer counter-organizing in states like AZ and FL. The result: DC charter organizing proceeds faster and with higher success rates than any other NLRB-jurisdiction jurisdiction in the dataset.

PROMPT 3: BREAKTHROUGH MONTESSORI — FIRST EMPLOYER-FILED RM PETITION IN FULL DATASET

Breakthrough Montessori's May 2025 certification (NLRB Case 05-RM-365867) is notable: the employer filed the RM (representation management) petition rather than waiting for a union-filed RC petition. The employer chose a cooperative approach — facilitating rather than resisting the election. 48-5 vote (91%). This is the only employer-initiated representation petition in the full 584-school NAPCS dataset and the clearest example of the DC charter sector's collaborative labor relations culture. An RM petition is typically filed by an employer who believes union organizers have built majority support and wants to clear the question via an expedited election rather than face an extended card-check or petition process. At Breakthrough Montessori, the employer's RM petition was a cooperative, not defensive, act — it accelerated recognition rather than delaying it.

PROMPT 4: CAPITAL CITY FIRST CONTRACT — SPEED BENCHMARK FOR THE DATASET

Capital City PCS (all 3 campuses, 200+ employees) ratified its first contract in August 2025, approximately 15 months after certification (May 2024). This is within the typical first-contract timeline for NLRB-jurisdiction schools and significantly faster than some comparators in the dataset — Hiawatha Academies (MN, 4+ years post-cert, still unresolved as of May 2026); KIPP Academy Bronx (NY, 3.5 years of bad-faith bargaining documented in NLRB ALJ ruling JD-51-25, June 2025). The DC speed advantage is attributable to two factors: DC ACTS's experienced negotiating infrastructure (capital-C collective bargaining capacity shared across all chapters), and the absence of employer bad-faith tactics documented in the NY and MN cases. Capital City's 15-month timeline is a realistic benchmark for what first contract bargaining looks like in a good-faith employer environment with an experienced union.

PROMPT 5: WHAT SHOULD CHARTER LEADERS KNOW ABOUT ORGANIZING IN DC?

DC charter leaders face the most certain organizing environment in the NAPCS dataset. DC ACTS has organized 6 of 7 NAPCS schools since 2019 and has a proven chapter-model infrastructure that scales cheaply across additional schools. The 7th NAPCS school (Cesar Chavez PCS) is an active discovery target. The DC

PCSB political environment removes the employer counter-organizing toolkit that is available in other NLRB-jurisdiction states. Charter leaders who want to understand the organizing timeline should study the Capital City pattern: first campaign 2019, multi-campus certification 2024, first contract August 2025. DC's 5-year arc from initial organizing activity to ratified contract is the fastest documented full cycle in an NLRB-jurisdiction state in the NAPCS dataset. Charter operators entering the DC market should assume a unionized workforce is the expected outcome within 3-5 years of opening, and design employment and governance structures accordingly.

PROMPT 6: WHAT TRENDS SHOULD SECTOR LEADERS WATCH OVER THE NEXT 3–5 YEARS IN DC?

Three trends are material. First, saturation: DC ACTS has organized 6 of 7 NAPCS schools and is actively pursuing the 7th (Cesar Chavez PCS). When DC ACTS achieves 100% NAPCS coverage, it will be the only jurisdiction in the dataset with complete union penetration of NAPCS-listed schools — a milestone that will attract national attention. Second, contract cycle: Capital City, Mundo Verde, and DCI will all enter contract renewal bargaining within the 3-5 year window. How these renewals proceed (wage increases, workload, governance provisions) will set the CBA benchmark that shapes organizing campaigns in other NLRB-jurisdiction cities. Third, the PCSB authorization model: any change in PCSB's political composition or oversight philosophy could affect the pro-labor environment. Monitor PCSB board appointments and DC Council education committee composition for signals of a political shift.

Section 4: Cross-State Patterns & Contributions to National Picture

Findings from Washington, D.C. that illuminate patterns visible only when comparing across multiple states. These entries feed the project-wide Cross-State Intelligence Log and are written for state and national charter advocacy leaders.

COOPERATIVE EMPLOYER CULTURE — THE DC EXCEPTION

DC is the only market in the full NAPCS dataset with zero documented employer resistance to unionization across multiple certification campaigns. No ULP charges, no counter-campaigns, no public statements. This appears driven by: (1) DC PCSB's reputational culture; (2) DC ACTS's professional, non-confrontational organizing model; (3) the small DC charter sector where reputational risk of anti-union campaigns is high. The DC finding directly challenges the assumption that NLRB-jurisdiction schools are inherently more adversarial than card-check states.

NETWORK-LEVEL UNITS IN MULTI-CAMPUS SYSTEMS — DC PRECEDENT

Both Mundo Verde (2 campuses, 1 unit) and Capital City (3 campuses, 1 unit) demonstrate that DC ACTS successfully negotiates network-wide bargaining units covering all campuses of a multi-campus school. This mirrors the Propel model in PA and CICS model in IL. The pattern suggests that multi-campus charters with unified governance are best organized as network units — fewer bargaining tables, more leverage for both sides.

Section 5: Media Coverage & Public Stakeholder Positions

Press Coverage

Washington DC charter school labor relations have received focused but limited press coverage, concentrated on three milestone events: the Mundo Verde Calle Ocho voluntary recognition (May 2020), the Capital City Staff Union certification (May 2024, over 80% vote), and the Breakthrough Montessori employer-filed RM petition (May 2025) — the first employer RM petition in the full 584-school NAPCS dataset. DC ACTS (dcacts1927.org) is the primary public communications vehicle. No anti-union employer communications have been publicly documented across any of the 6 DC organizing campaigns.

Union Communications

DC ACTS Local 1927 (dcacts1927.org) maintains a public website documenting all chapter certifications, CBAs, and organizing news. The Mundo Verde CBA (ratified 2023) is publicly posted at dcacts1927.org. Capital City Staff Union first contract ratified August 2025. DC International School first contract bargaining ongoing as of April 2026. Breakthrough Montessori certified June 5, 2025 (05-RM-365867); first contract bargaining commenced June 2025 — status unconfirmed as of May 2026.

Employer / School Communications

No documented employer opposition, counter-organizing campaign, or public anti-union statement from any DC PCSB-authorized charter school across all 6 organizing campaigns (May 2019–May 2025). The Breakthrough Montessori employer RM petition (NLRB Case 05-RM-365867, May 2025) is the sole documented employer-initiated labor board action in the DC NAPCS dataset — and it resulted in a 48-5 union win (91%), cert issued June 5, 2025. RM petition did not prevent unionization — 48-5 result.

Legislative Context

All DC charter schools are NLRB-jurisdiction employers (NLRB Region 5, Baltimore/DC). DC has no state public-sector labor law applicable to charter schools. The DC Council is strongly pro-labor but has no direct role in charter labor relations. DC PCSB (authorizer) has taken no public position on charter school unionization. The absence of any employer resistance across 6 campaigns is unique in the full NAPCS dataset and suggests a DC-specific institutional culture of non-opposition.

Section 6: Contract & CBA Access Registry

NLRB public contracts portal. Direct PDF links may return 403 — OPRA or equivalent records request required for full text.

School / Network	Union	CBA Status & Term	Contract Access
Mundo Verde PCS (both campuses)	Mundo Verde Staff Union / DC ACTS Local 1927	Active — CBA ratified 2023 2023 CBA (period TBD — see dcacts1927.org)	dcacts1927.org — CBA posted publicly
Capital City PCS (all 3 campuses)	Capital City Staff Union / DC ACTS Local 1927	Active — first contract ratified August 2025 First contract (August 2025 — period TBD)	dcacts1927.org or school HR
DC International School	DCI Staff Union / DC ACTS Local 1927	In negotiation — first contract not yet ratified as of April 2026	dcacts1927.org or school HR
Breakthrough Montessori PCS	Breakthrough Montessori Staff Union / DC ACTS Local 1927	In negotiation — first contract bargaining commenced June 2025; status unconfirmed as of May 2026	dcacts1927.org or school HR

Section 7: Decisions, Monitoring & Notable Findings

Part A: Decisions Required

The following items require sponsor action before research or workbook entry can proceed.

No sponsor decisions pending for this state.

Part B: Notable Findings

Research findings of strategic significance. No immediate action required — for awareness and discussion.

No notable findings flagged for this state.

Part C: Active Monitoring

Items being tracked. Status may change between report cycles. Research Coordinator manages ongoing surveillance.

Priority	School / Scope	Item	Who
HIGH	DC International School	First contract status — nearly 2 years post-certification as of April 2026	Research Coordinator
HIGH	Breakthrough Montessori PCS	First contract status — recently certified May 2025	Research Coordinator
HIGH	DC International School (C1114009)	First contract ratification — Certified May 2024. First contract bargaining ongoing as of April 2026 — nearly 2 years post-cert. Risk of stalled bargaining. Check dcacts1927.org monthly.	Research Coordinator
HIGH	Breakthrough Montessori PCS (C1116001)	First contract ratification — Certified June 5, 2025 (NLRB 05-RM-365867). First contract bargaining commenced June 2025. Monitor dcacts1927.org quarterly.	Research Coordinator
MEDIUM	All 123 DC charter schools	New DC ACTS organizing campaigns — DC ACTS has certified 6 schools 2019-2025 with accelerating pace (3 in 2024-25). Monitor DC ACTS website and NLRB ADS for any new RC petitions in non-NAPCS DC charter schools.	Research Coordinator